TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Definition of Communication

What communication is — definitions, the elements and process of a single act of communication, feedback, noise, and the conditions that make communication effective.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 2 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. Definitions

The word comes from the Latin *communis* — "common": communication is the making of a common understanding between people. Definitions used in this course:

- **In substance (standard management texts):** communication is the transfer of information and understanding from one person to another — a process of transmitting messages and sharing meanings.
- **Keith Davis:** "Communication is the process of passing information and understanding from one person to another."
- **A working definition:** communication is a process by which a sender encodes a message, transmits it through a channel to a receiver, who decodes it and returns feedback — so that a shared meaning is established.

Note what the definitions insist on: information merely *sent* is not yet communication. Communication is complete only when the receiver **understands** the message as the sender intended — a delivered circular that nobody understood has failed as communication even though the sending was perfect.

2. The process: elements of communication

ELEMENT	ROLE
Sender (encoder)	The person who has an idea or information to share and puts it into symbols — words, figures, gestures. Encoding well (choosing the receiver's language and level) is half the art.
Message	The information itself as encoded: the letter, the instruction, the report, the signal.
Channel / medium	The route the message travels: face-to-face speech, telephone, letter, email, notice board, gesture.

Receiver (decoder)	The person who receives the symbols and translates them back into meaning — influenced by their knowledge, attitude and state of mind.
Feedback	The receiver's response returning to the sender — the nod, the reply, the completed task — confirming (or denying) that the meaning arrived. Feedback converts one-way sending into two-way communication.
Noise	Anything that distorts the message en route: literal noise, poor handwriting, wrong vocabulary, prejudice, a bad telephone line, the receiver's preoccupation.
Context	The situation — place, time, relationship, culture — in which the exchange happens and which colours every element above.

The process is a loop, not a line: sender → message → channel → receiver → feedback → sender again, with noise threatening every arrow. In continuing exchanges the roles rotate — today's receiver is the next moment's sender.

3. Barriers and effective communication

Noise of every kind erects **barriers**: *physical* (distance, noise, poor equipment), *language/semantic* (jargon, ambiguity, a word carrying different meanings to sender and receiver), *psychological* (prejudice, fear of the superior, inattention, distrust), and *organisational* (long chains of command distorting a message at every relay — the office "Chinese whispers"). Effective communication is the systematic removal of barriers:

- **Clarity** — one message, plainly structured, in the receiver's language.
- **Completeness and conciseness** — everything needed, nothing extra.
- **Correct channel** — urgent and personal by voice; permanent and provable in writing.
- **Feedback actively sought** — questions, paraphrase-back ("so you will deliver Friday — correct?"), observation of results.
- **Listening** — the receiver's half of the skill, and the rarer one.

4. A textile-floor illustration

A dyeing master phones the laboratory: "The lot is two points red — adjust and re-run." Every element is present: sender (master), encoding ("two points red" — laboratory shorthand a newcomer would not decode), channel (telephone, with factory noise attacking it), receiver (lab assistant), feedback (the corrected recipe sent back and, ultimately, the re-dyed lot itself), context (a delivery deadline colouring everyone's reading of "urgent"). The same instruction in writing, with the lab reading recorded and the target shade attached, removes three barriers at once — the whole of this course in one phone call.

5. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Encoding / decoding	Putting an idea into symbols / translating received symbols back into meaning.
Channel	The medium by which a message travels (speech, letter, email, gesture).
Feedback	The receiver’s response that informs the sender how the message was understood.
Noise	Any distortion introduced between sender’s meaning and receiver’s understanding.
Barrier	A persistent source of noise: physical, semantic, psychological or organisational.
Two-way communication	Communication with feedback, as opposed to one-way sending without response.

6. Key points and summary

- Communication is the establishment of shared meaning — complete only when the receiver understands as intended, not merely when a message is sent.
- The process loops through sender (encoding), message, channel, receiver (decoding) and feedback, under attack from noise at every step and coloured by context.
- Effectiveness is barrier removal: clarity, completeness, right channel, sought feedback and real listening.

7. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Define communication, and explain why “the notice was sent to all departments” is not yet proof that communication happened.
2. List the elements of the communication process in order, with the function of each in one line.
3. Classify these barriers — factory din drowning a phone call; a supervisor’s order misunderstood because of jargon; a worker afraid to ask his manager a question — and give one remedy for each.
4. What does feedback add that mere sending lacks? Give two forms feedback can take in a factory.
5. Rewrite this barrier-rich instruction into an effective one: “Handle the urgent lot ASAP and sort out the shade thing.” State what you fixed.
6. “Communication is a loop, not a line.” Explain with the roles of sender and receiver.
7. Choose channels: (a) a safety rule that must be provable a year later, (b) a machine breakdown needing help now, (c) a change of shift pattern affecting forty workers — with reasons.

Answer key

1. Communication is the process of transferring information and understanding so that a shared meaning is established between sender and receiver. Sending proves only dispatch; if departments misread or ignore the notice, no common understanding exists — the defining outcome is missing.
2. Sender/encoder (originates and encodes) → message (the encoded content) → channel (the route) → receiver/decoder (interprets) → feedback (the response confirming understanding), with noise and context acting throughout.
3. Din: physical barrier — move the call, use written confirmation. Jargon: semantic barrier — use the receiver's vocabulary or define terms. Fear: psychological barrier — invite questions, respond without blame, check understanding by paraphrase.
4. Feedback confirms whether the intended meaning arrived and lets the sender correct misunderstanding — without it, sending is one-way. Forms: a verbal/written confirmation of the instruction; the completed work itself matching (or failing) the instruction.
5. Example rewrite: "Please run Lot 214 (blue polyester, 500 kg) next, before Lot 215, and match the shade to standard sample B-7; report the lab dip result to me by 14:00." Fixed: named the lot, the order of work, the exact target, the report-back and deadline — clarity, completeness, feedback.
6. Because the receiver's feedback returns to the sender, who then responds — each party alternately sends and receives. A one-way line ends at delivery; communication continues until understanding is confirmed and acted on.
7. (a) Writing (letter/circular on file) — permanence and proof. (b) Voice in person or by phone — immediacy and two-way clarification. (c) Writing backed by a briefing meeting — reach and record, with feedback from those affected.
